VARIANTS OVER THE YEARS



MiG-21FL
Early frontline 2nd-generation variant, capable of high-speed interceptions and basic air-to-air combat for short-range missions

MiG-21M
Optimised for ground-attack missions with a strengthened airframe, increased fuel capacity and improved missile load; marked the entry of 3rd-gen fighters in the IAF in early '70s

MiG-21bis
Mainstay from the 1980s, equipped with a more powerful engine and upgraded flight controls; delivered enhanced speed, climb rate and combat performance

MiG-21 Bison
Modernised version of the bis variant, incorporated 4th-gen avionics and missiles; extended operational life of the fleet into the 21st century

MiG-21U/UM
Twin-seat trainer version; allowed safe transition for pilots from subsonic aircraft to the supersonic MiG-21s

DARKER LEGACY

450+

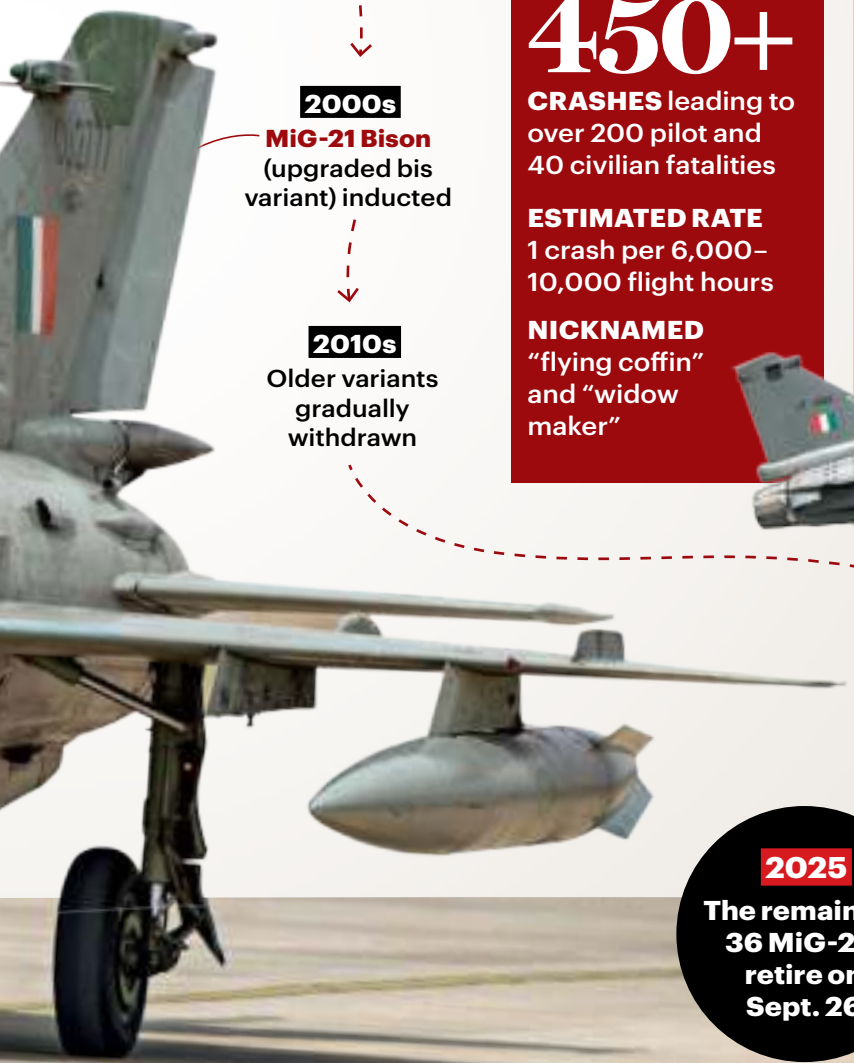
CRASHES leading to over 200 pilot and 40 civilian fatalities

ESTIMATED RATE
1 crash per 6,000–10,000 flight hours

NICKNAMED
"flying coffin" and "widow maker"

GENERATIONAL LEAP

- MiG-21s are being retired in favour of indigenously developed **Tejas Mk-1A fighters.** HAL has received orders for 83 jets; 97 more in the pipeline
- The Mk-1A is equipped with modern radar, electronic warfare gear and digital cockpit
- This marks a generational shift to modern 4.5-gen jets; first induction likely by 2025 end



2000s
MiG-21 Bison (upgraded bis variant) inducted

2010s
Older variants gradually withdrawn

2019
A MiG-21 Bison piloted by Wg Cdr Abhinandan Varthaman reportedly downs a PAF F-16 before being hit itself, a day after the IAF's Balakot airstrike

2025
The remaining 36 MiG-21s retire on Sept. 26